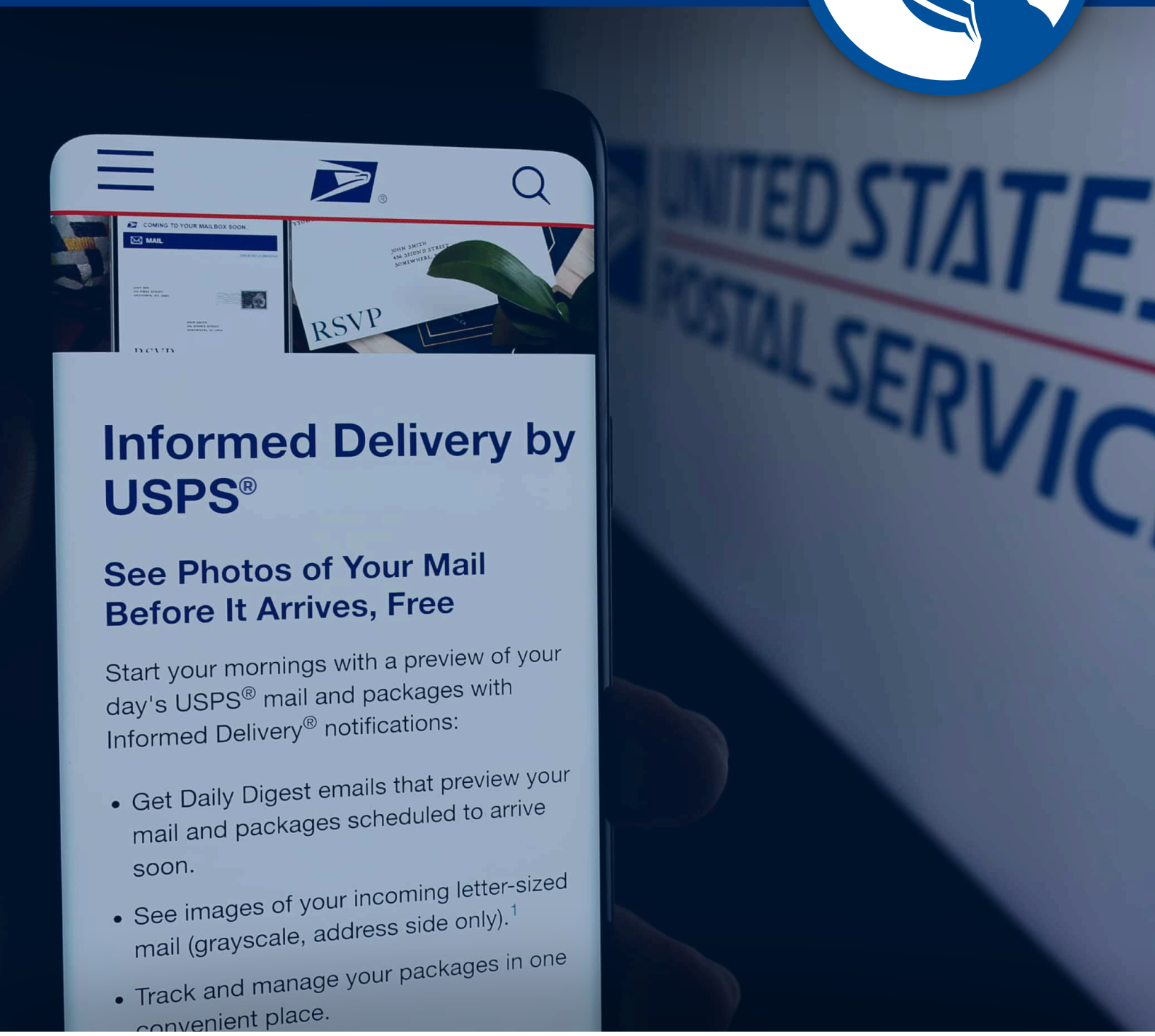
USPS® Informed Delivery®

for Businesses & Non-Profits
Complete Guide [2026]

A White Paper by Cornerstone Services, Inc.



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Table of Contents

Cover

Introduction 2

Section 1: What Is USPS® Informed Delivery® ? **3-6**

- Background & History 3
- Consumer Benefits: Why People Sign Up 3
- How the Service Works 4
- Competitor Comparison: Delivery Notification Services 4
- Adoption & Engagement: The Numbers That Matter 5-6
- Geographic Reach 6

Section 2: Consumer Benefits vs. Mailer Opportunities **7-8**

- Consumer Benefits Summary 7
- Business & Non-Profit Mailer Opportunities 7
- Pros and Cons: An Honest Assessment 8

Section 3: How to Set Up an Informed Delivery® Campaign **8-12**

- Step 1: Register for the USPS® Business Customer Gateway (BCG) 8-9
- Step 2: Configure Your Mailer ID (MID) and Customer Registration ID (CRID) 9
- Step 3: Design Your Ride-Along Image 9-10
- Step 4: Upload Campaign to the Informed Delivery® Mailer Campaign Portal 10-11
- Step 5: Link the Intelligent Mail® Barcode (IMb®) to Your Campaign 11
- Step 6: Monitor Results in the Campaign Dashboard 11
- Glossary: Key Terms 11-12

Section 4: Best Practices for Ride-Along Images **12-13**

- Design for the Context 12
- Call-to-Action Language 12-13
- Landing Page Alignment 13
- A/B Testing 13

Section 5: Case Studies — Actual and Documented Campaign Results **13-16**

- Case Study 1: Pittsburgh Pirates — Testing Offer Architecture 13-14
- Case Study 2: Bono's Pit Bar-B-Q — Grayscale vs. Full Color 15
- Implications for Not-For-Profit Orgs and Small Business Mailers 16

Section 6: Measuring ROI **16-18**

- Available Metrics From the USPS® Portal 16
- Tracking Conversions 16
- Recommended Measurement Structure: Three-Group Design 17
- Cost Structure by Mail Volume 17-18

Conclusion: Five Structural Advantages — and What They Require **18-20**

- Why Partner with Professional Mailers 19

Bibliography & Source Citations **21-22**

Introduction: Standing Out Before the Mail Arrives

Every year, non-profit development officers and small business marketers face a version of the same challenge: their direct mail pieces compete for attention in a mailbox that receives, on average, only 2.2 pieces of mail per delivery day. The competition is no longer primarily from other mailers – it is from email inboxes, mobile device notifications, and social media feeds which have trained recipients to scroll past commercial messages without pausing.

Into this environment, the United States Postal Service® (USPS®) introduced Informed Delivery

Informed Delivery® — a free, opt-in consumer notification service that gives subscribers a digital preview of their incoming mail before the carrier reaches the door. For organizations already investing in direct mail campaigns, this represented an interesting opportunity – to benefit from a second, marketer-controlled digital touchpoint delivered at no additional postage or ancillary cost – and to reach an audience that has actively chosen to receive such notifications.

As of March 2025, 72.9 million active subscribers receive the Daily Digest email at a 60.1% open rate — more than double the 25–30% benchmark for standard marketing email. One in three U.S. households is now enrolled toreceive Informed Delivery® notifications. From regional not-for-profit organizations running year-end appeals, to large multi-national businesses promoting seasonal offers, those numbers represent a meaningful portion of any targeted mail file already engaged before the envelope lands.

This guide attempts to explain how Informed Delivery® works, what the performance data reveals from the platform, and what specifically the implementation actually requires. Additionally, we will include the technical overhead that seems to prevent most organizations from capturing Informed Delivery's® full value. For many marketers, we will consider if the implementation solution may be best resolved by through an experienced mail service provider in contrast to in-house deployment efforts, and whether and outside provider might produce materially better results.

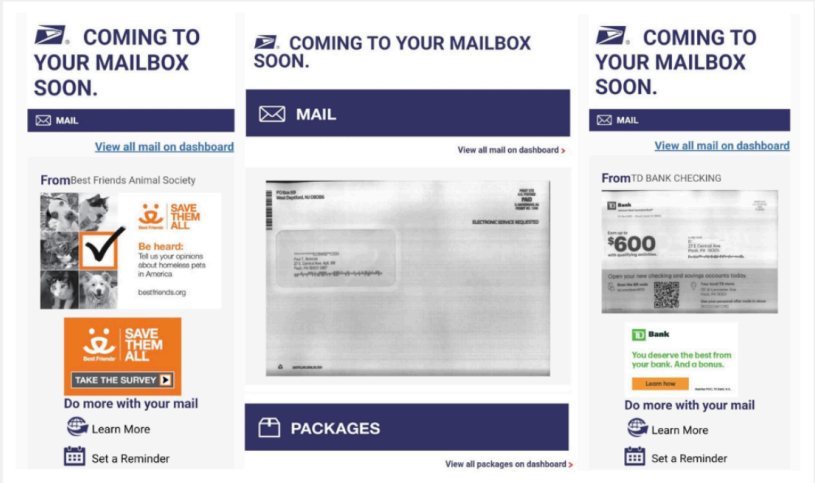


Figure 1: Real USPS® Informed Delivery® Daily Digest emails showing three scenarios — (left) a non-profit campaign from Best Friends Animal Society with a full-color ride-along image and CTA; (center) a standard grayscale-only mailpiece scan with no ride-along; (right) a TD Bank campaign with a branded ride-along image and 'Learn How' CTA. The contrast between center and the flanking examples illustrates exactly what mailers gain by running an Informed Delivery® interactive campaign. Source: USPS®.

Section 1: What Is USPS® Informed Delivery®?

Background & History

The USPS® has scanned incoming mail as standard operational protocol since the early 2000s, a practice initially implemented after the 2001 anthrax letter attacks which required rapid mail tracking capability. For more than a decade, those scan images were used exclusively for internal processing — sorting, routing, and delivery sequencing.

In 2014, USPS® recognized that this existing imaging infrastructure could deliver direct consumer value. The agency launched a pilot program in Northern Virginia with approximately 10,000 users, expanded to the New York City metropolitan area in late 2015, and achieved nationwide rollout in April 2017 — covering nearly all 42,000 ZIP Codes™ across the country. By January 2019, enrollment had reached 14.9 million subscribers. By 2021, over 51 million users had registered, representing a 43% year-over-year growth rate. As of March 2025, the service reports 72.9 million active subscribers.

The service was purpose-built on top of existing USPS® infrastructure at no additional cost to consumers or to the Postal Service's existing operational budget. Today, Informed Delivery® is not a pilot program or an experimental marketing initiative — it is a mature, nationally deployed service operating at postal scale since 2017, with nearly a decade of performance data.

Consumer Benefits: Why People Sign Up

Understanding why consumers enroll in Informed Delivery® is necessary context for any organization planning an Informed Delivery® marketing campaign. Of note, the Informed Delivery® service was designed to solve practical -consumer problems and was not initially intended to become a marketing vehicle for third party advertisers.

Consequently, the primary driver of enrollment is mail security and theft prevention. Subscribers know precisely which pieces of mail are expected on any given day, making it possible to identify missing items and report them to USPS® quickly.

A secondary benefit for recipients is scheduling convenience — knowing that the imminent arrival important document (e.g. a tax document, a medical bill, or even a rent check, Social Security check or distribution check) affords postal customer subscribers some lifestyle planning benefits. A third driver for subscription adoption is package management: Informed Delivery® integrates USPS® tracking data, thereby permitting subscribers to perform home pick-up or schedule redeliveries, provide delivery instructions, and report non-arrivals — all within the same interface.

The 89% satisfaction rate reported in USPS®'s own 2018 user survey (8,631 respondents across 5,784 ZIP Codes™) reflects this genuine utility. Subscribers open the Daily Digest because they want to see what is coming — not because a brand has enticed them. That behavioral origin is the reason the platform's email open rate (58.6–60.1%) runs more than double the benchmark for promotional email.

How the Service Works

Every letter-sized mailpiece processed through USPS® automated sorting equipment is imaged by high-speed cameras as it moves through the facility at processing speeds exceeding 36,000 pieces per hour. This imaging is standard mail handling and not a supplemental process.

For enrolled subscribers, USPS®'s automated matching system cross-references scanned images against registered addresses. The result is a Daily Digest email — compiled and delivered between 3:00 AM and 11:00 AM local time — showing subscribers the grayscale exterior scans of incoming

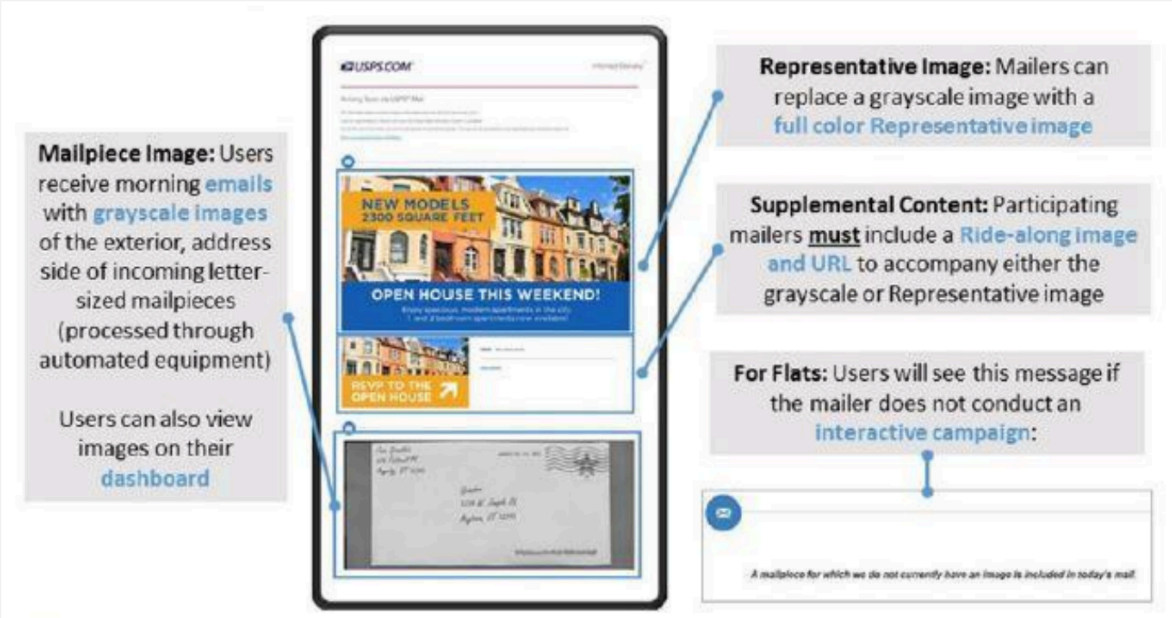


Figure 2: The USPS® Informed Delivery® Daily Digest as displayed on a mobile device, showing (1) the grayscale mailpiece scan, (2) the mailer's full-color ride-along image with clickable URL, and (3) the Representative Image option for flat-sized mailpieces. Source: USPS®.

Note on mail classes and imaging: USPS® automated imaging currently applies to letter-sized mailpieces processed through high-speed letter sorting equipment. Flat-sized pieces (large envelopes, catalogs, magazines) and parcels are not universally imaged for Informed Delivery® preview purposes, though package tracking notifications are provided separately. Mailers should confirm imaging eligibility for their specific mail class before planning a campaign.

letter mail scheduled for delivery that day. Subscribers may also view incoming mail through the USPS.com® dashboard or the USPS® Mobile App (available for iOS and Android).

Competitor Comparison: Delivery Notification Services

Informed Delivery® is not the only delivery notification service in the U.S. market. The table below clarifies where it sits relative to comparable offerings and why it is uniquely suited to mailers running letter-mail campaigns.

Service	Provider	Coverage	Consumer Cost	Mail Preview?	Mailer Campaign Feature?
Informed Delivery®	USPS®	Letter mail + USPS® packages	Free	Yes — grayscale scans	Yes — ride-along image + URL
UPS My Choice®	UPS®	UPS® packages only	Free / $19.99–$40/yr Premium	No	No
FedEx Delivery Manager®	FedEx®	FedEx® packages only	Free / Premium tier	No	No
Royal Mail Delivery Manager	Royal Mail (UK)	Royal Mail items	Free	No	Limited
Canada Post Informed Delivery	Canada Post	Letter mail (pilot)	Free (pilot)	Yes (pilot)	No

The defining distinction: UPS My Choice® and FedEx Delivery Manager® manage package delivery — rerouting, scheduling, signature authorization — but neither previews letter-sized mail simply because such private carriers do not carry letter mail.

Only USPS® operates the universal letter delivery network, and Informed Delivery® is the only platform that turns that network into a pre-delivery digital touchpoint for mailers.

Adoption & Engagement: The Numbers That Matter

Metric	Figure	Source
Active subscribers	72.9 million	USPS®, March 2025
U.S. household penetration	34.7%	USPS® Year in Review
Average email open rate	58.6–60.1%	USPS® FY2025 data
Annual impressions generated	45.1 billion	USPS® portal
Year-over-year subscriber growth	17%	USPS®
Subscriber satisfaction rate	89%	USPS® consumer survey, 2018

More than one in three American households now receives the Daily Digest. To put that in potential marketing campaign terms: a 50,000-piece mailing statistically reaches approximately 17,350 Informed Delivery® subscribers. Translation: 17,350 recipients may see a digital preview of the mailer before it reaches the mailbox at no additional postage cost.

The 58.6–60.1% open rate is the platform's most consequential performance metric for mailers. Standard marketing email benchmarks sit at 25–30%, while unsolicited non-profit email outreach typically achieves even lower open rates of 15–20%. Informed Delivery® subscribers open their digest because it has

genuine utility — any ride-along image presented in that context inherits that engagement habit.

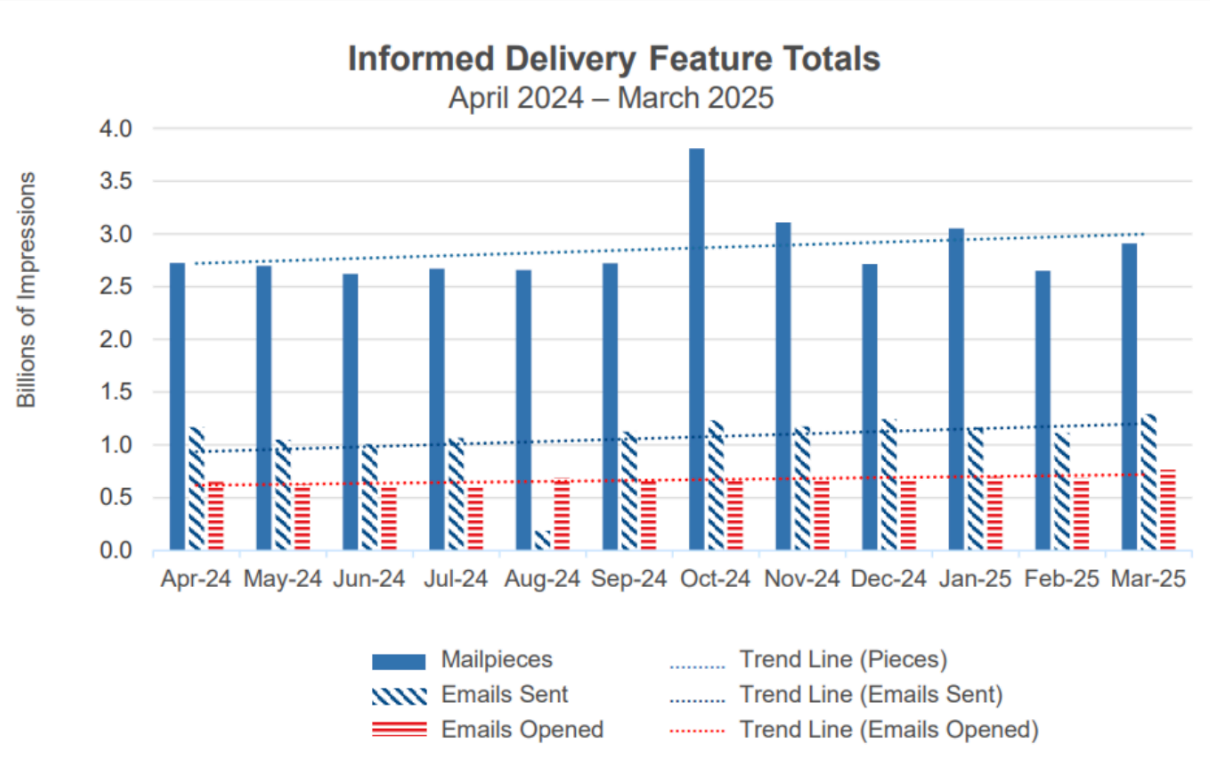


Figure 3: USPS® Informed Delivery® Feature Totals, April 2024–March 2025 — monthly mail piece impressions, emails sent, and emails opened across the platform's 72.9 million active subscribers.

Source: USPS® Informed Delivery® Year in Review, April 2024–March 2025

Geographic Reach

USPS® Informed Delivery® is available to eligible residential, business, and PO Box™ customers in all 50 states, Washington D.C., Puerto Rico, Guam, and the U.S. Virgin Islands — covering approximately 168.6 million delivery points. Most residential addresses are eligible; however, multi-unit dwellings without individually coded mailboxes and some rural addresses may not yet qualify. Eligibility can be confirmed at usps.com/informeddelivery. Urban metro penetration currently runs slightly higher (38–42%) than rural areas (30–35%). However, this 8–10 point differential is notably narrower than the disparities observed in social media (28-point urban/rural gap), streaming services (34-point gap), or mobile payment platforms among donors aged 55 and older (41-point gap). For organizations mailing into geographically diverse lists — a consistent challenge for non-profits with nationally dispersed donor files Informed Delivery® 's relatively uniform reach may represent a meaningful potential advantage over digital-only alternatives that systematically underserve rural and older audiences.

Section 2: Consumer Benefits vs. Mailer Opportunities

Consumer Benefits Summary

Consumer Benefit	Description
Mail preview	Grayscale scans of incoming letter-sized mail, delivered before the carrier
Package tracking	USPS® package delivery notifications and status updates
Delivery management	Schedule redeliveries, provide delivery instructions, report non-arrivals
Mail security	Know exactly what should arrive — identify missing or tampered items
Free & voluntary	No cost to enroll; identity verification protects privacy
Multi-platform access	Email digest, USPS.com dashboard, and iOS/Android mobile app

Business & Non-Profit Mailer Opportunities

Opportunity	Description	Cost to Mailer
Ride-along image	Full-color branded image with clickable URL alongside the mailpiece scan	Free (USPS® charges no distribution fee)
Pre-delivery digital touchpoint	Recipient sees brand/offer before physical mail arrives	Creative design costs only
Campaign analytics	Impressions, clicks, CTR by ZIP Code™, engagement timing	Free via USPS® portal
USPS® postage promotion discount	1% postage discount for qualifying Informed Delivery® campaigns (+ 0.5% for eDoc submitters)	Requires eDoc submission
A/B testing	Geographic split testing of different ride-along images	Creative design costs only

Important note on costs: USPS® does not charge mailers any incremental distribution fee for including a ride-along image in Informed Delivery® emails. Per the official USPS® FAQ, conducting an Informed Delivery® interactive campaign "is provided at no additional cost to mailers." The Postal Service® does reserve the right to monetize new aspects of the service in the future. Actual costs associated with a campaign are typically limited to the following

(1) ride-along image design;

(2) any professional services fee from a mail service provider for campaign setup and management; and,

(3) the underlying postage and production costs of the direct mail piece itself, which the organization would incur regardless.

Pros and Cons: An Honest Assessment

Factor	Favorable	Consideration
Audience reach	72.9M active subscribers, 34.7% household penetration	Only reaches enrolled subscribers — not all mail recipients
Cost	No USPS® distribution fee; potential 1% postage discount	Creative design and professional setup have real costs
Segmentation	Geographic targeting via ZIP Code™ analytics	Cannot segment by demographics or interests within mail file
Measurement	Impressions, clicks, CTR by geography	Online conversions require UTM tracking setup — not automatic
Mail class eligibility	Letter-sized First-Class™ and Marketing Mail®	EDDM® Retail mailings are not eligible (see Section 3)
Accessibility	Works via basic email — no broadband or app required	Requires email address; recipients without one are unreachable

Section 3: How to Set Up an Informed Delivery® Campaign

Setting up an Informed Delivery® interactive campaign requires coordination across USPS® systems, creative production, and mail production schedules. The process is free but mildly technically involved. Organizations attempting this without prior experience frequently encounter errors at the Mailer ID configuration stage or the IMb® barcode (Intelligent Mail Barcode®) integration stage — the two points where most first-time campaigns are delayed or fail to attain intended outcomes.

Is Informed Delivery ® right for your volume? While each advertising or not-for-profit organization must undertake its own internal review; it is our (the authors') professional assessment that when mailing fewer than 5,000 pieces, the statistical incremental subscriber reach (approximately 1,735 Informed Delivery® households at national average penetration) may only cover the return value of an entity's setup time. Please consult Section 6 for volume-specific ROI scenarios before proceeding.

Step 1: Register for the USPS® Business Customer Gateway (BCG)

All Informed Delivery® campaign management is conducted through the USPS® Business Customer Gateway — the central portal for USPS® business mailers providing access to PostalOne!®

the Mailer Campaign Portal (MCP), mailing permit management, and post-campaign analytics. Registration requires organizational credentials and typically takes 3–5 business days for USPS® approval.

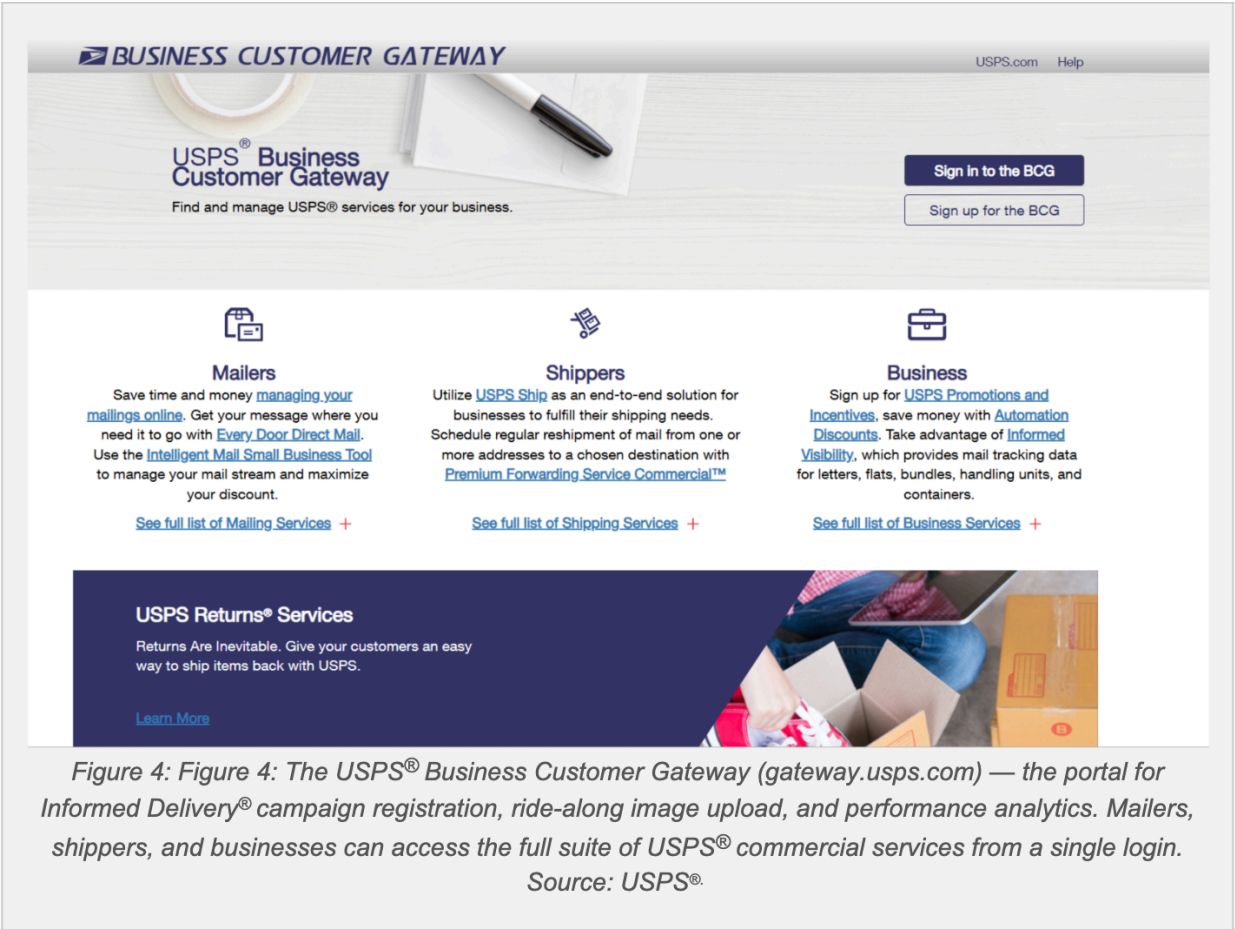


Figure 4: Figure 4: The USPS® Business Customer Gateway (gateway.usps.com) — the portal for Informed Delivery® campaign registration, ride-along image upload, and performance analytics. Mailers, shippers, and businesses can access the full suite of USPS® commercial services from a single login. Source: USPS®.

Step 2: Configure Your Mailer ID (MID) and Customer Registration ID (CRID)

USPS® assigns each registered mailer two identifiers central to campaign functionality:

• Mailer ID (MID): A 6- or 9-digit number that identifies the organization sending mail, embedded in every Intelligent Mail® barcode (IMb®). The MID is the link between the physical mailpiece and the digital ride-along image.

• Customer Registration ID (CRID): A unique identifier assigned at the organization level in the Business Customer Gateway. Required for portal access and distinct from the MID

Without proper MID configuration, the USPS® system cannot match incoming mail scans to the corresponding ride-along content. This is the most common technical failure point for first-time mailers.

Step 3: Design Your Ride-Along Image

Design context: The ride-along appears alongside a grayscale envelope scan in a lowstimulation visual environment. High contrast, minimal copy, and immediate brand recognition are functional requirements at this scale. Recommended success keys:

Specification	Requirement
Dimensions	300×200 px (standard) or 600×400 px (high-resolution)
File size	Maximum 200 KB
File format	JPG or PNG, RGB color space
Content restrictions	Static only — no animation, video, or executable code
Required element	Clickable destination URL (landing page, donation form, event registration)
Optional element	Representative image (required for flat-sized mailings)

* One headline.

* One CTA (Call to Action — the instruction directing the recipient to take a specific action).

* Nothing competing with either the headline or CTA.

Platform-wide data shows that images referencing the physical mailpiece consistently outperform standalone branded graphics on click-through rate (see Section 5).



Figure 5: An annotated example of a well-designed ride-along image at the standard 300×200px dimensions. Key elements: logo for brand reinforcement, reverse type on solid color for legibility, message synced to the physical mailpiece, and a clear compelling CTA. Source: USPS®.

Step 4: Upload Campaign to the Informed Delivery® Mailer Campaign Portal

Campaigns must be uploaded 5–10 business days before the intended mail-in-home date. Each campaign is linked to the mailing's in-home dates — not mail entry dates — so coordination with the mail production schedule is essential. Here are important considerations:

• Maximum campaign duration: 45 days per campaign period

• Campaigns require USPS® pre-approval of ride-along image and URL

• Political mail and certain restricted content categories are not eligible

• USPS® Promotion discount (1%) requires enrollment via BCG Manage Permit section at least two hours before sending mail

Step 5: Link the Intelligent Mail® Barcode (IMb®) to Your Campaign

Every physical mailpiece participating in an Informed Delivery® campaign must carry a properly formatted Intelligent Mail® barcode (IMb®).

The IMb® encodes routing information, the Mailer ID, and a serial number that allows USPS® to match each incoming mail scan to its corresponding ride-along image. This IMb® integration requirement is the primary reason Informed Delivery® interactive campaigns require a mail service provider or mailing software that generates compliant barcodes. Consumerfacing mail sent without a properly formatted IMb® — including Every Door Direct Mail® (EDDM®) Retail mailings — cannot be linked to an Informed Delivery® ride-along campaign.

EDDM® & Informed Delivery®: Important Clarification	EDDM® Retail mailings use a non-automation, simplified address format (e.g. "Postal Customer") which does not utilize individual Intelligent Mail® barcodes (IMb®) that identify specific recipient addresses. As a result, EDDM® Retail mailings are not eligible for Informed Delivery® interactive campaigns with ride-along images. Organizations seeking to combine geographic saturation mailing with Informed Delivery® capability should consider using “occupant-resident” saturation data or consult a mail service provider such as Cornerstone Services, Inc. (www.crst.net) regarding use using targeted Marketing Mail® over simplified addressing.

Step 6: Monitor Results in the Campaign Dashboard

After mailpice fulfillment and postal delivery, the USPS® Mailer Campaign Portal avails four core metrics: impressions (Daily Digest opens containing the campaign), unique clicks on the ridealong image, click-through rate (CTR) segmented by ZIP Code™, and engagement timing by delivery day. These metrics document engagement that occurred between mail entry and physical delivery — a window that, prior to Informed Delivery® , produced no data for mailers.

Glossary: Key Terms

IMb® (Intelligent Mail® Barcode): A USPS® barcode encoding routing info, Mailer ID, and serial number on each mailpiece. Required for Informed Delivery® campaign eligibility.

MID (Mailer ID): A 6- or 9-digit number assigned by USPS® identifying the organization sending mail. Embedded in the IMb®.

CRID (Customer Registration ID): A unique identifier for each organization registered in the USPS® Business Customer Gateway.

CTR (Click-Through Rate): The percentage of email recipients who click a link. Calculated as: Clicks ÷ Impressions × 100.

CPM (Cost Per Mille): The cost to generate 1,000 impressions. A standard digital advertising metric used to compare channel efficiency. 'Mille' is Latin for thousand.

CTA (Call to Action): The instruction directing the recipient to take a specific action — e.g., "Give Today," "Claim Your Discount," "Register Now."

UTM Parameters: Tags appended to a URL allowing web analytics platforms (e.g., Google Analytics) to identify traffic source. Example: ?utm_source=informeddelivery&utm_medium=email

A/B Testing: A controlled experiment comparing two versions of a creative element (e.g., two different ride-along images) against the same physical mailpiece. Most practical for mailings of 5,000+ pieces.

EDDM® (Every Door Direct Mail®): A USPS® saturation mailing program delivering to every address on selected carrier routes without requiring individual addressee names or IMb® barcodes. Not eligible for Informed Delivery® interactive campaigns.

Section 4: Best Practices for Ride-Along Images

Design for the Context

The ride-along image operates within tight constraints: 300×200 pixels, displayed alongside grayscale envelope scans in a functional, low-stimulation visual environment. The platform's most counterintuitive finding: representative images that visually reference the physical mail piece consistently outperform elaborate standalone graphics on click-through rate. A subscriber who recognizes the envelope in the ride-along develops curiosity about its contents. The digital preview and the physical piece reinforce one another. The ride-along image operates within tight constraints: 300×200 pixels, displayed alongside grayscale envelope scans in a functional, low-stimulation visual environment.

The platform's most counterintuitive finding: representative images that visually reference the physical mail piece consistently outperform elaborate standalone graphics on click-through rate. A subscriber who recognizes the envelope in the ride-along develops curiosity about its contents. The digital preview and the physical piece reinforce one another.

Call-to-Action Language

According to the Direct Marketing Association's (DMA's) response rate guidelines, action verbs tied to concrete recipient benefits consistently outperform generic engagement language:

• "Give Before December 31" outperforms "Donate Now"

• "Claim Your 20% Discount" outperforms "Learn More"

• "See What's Inside" primes physical mail engagement when immediate conversion is not the objective

• "Unlock Your Free Gift" outperforms passive language when an incentive is available

Urgency and recipient benefit drive action. When the objective is to foster physical mail engagement rather than drive immediate digital conversion, language that creates curiosity about the incoming mailpiece consistently outperforms direct asks.

Landing Page Alignment

The destination URL must deliver precisely what the ride-along implies. A generic homepage behind a campaign-specific CTA breaks the conversion path at the moment of highest intent, so mailers should consider dedicated sub-pages to guide Informed Delivery® recipient landing. For non-profit mailing campaigns, this means a donation form pre-loaded with campaign context — not the organization's homepage. For retail promotions, this means a landing page that immediately shows the offer previewed in the ride-along. The click that does not convert misses the analytics opportunity and could represent a data collection or metrics failure.

A/B Testing

Note: A/B testing is most practical for mailings of 5,000 pieces or more, where geographic splits produce statistically meaningful sample sizes.

The USPS® portal's geographic reporting makes Informed Delivery® one of the few direct mail channels where controlled creative testing is operationally straightforward.

Split the mail file by geography and test two ride-along images against the identical physical mailpiece. Test digitalfirst CTAs against physical-first CTAs. Test delivery day timing by market. Test grayscale representative images against full-color branded graphics (see Section 5 for why this test consistently surprises mailers).

Section 5: Case Studies — Actual and Documented Campaign Results

The following actual case studies are drawn from documented Informed Delivery® campaigns published by USPS® at uspsdelivers.com/informed-delivery-case-studies. They illustrate how organizations across sectors have applied the platform's testing capabilities to produce measurable outcomes.

Case Study 1: Pittsburgh Pirates — Testing Offer Architecture

The Challenge

The Pittsburgh Pirates planned a direct mail campaign to drive early-season ticket sales with a $5-off seat discount.

The organization had one physical mailpiece, one offer, and one production run — but no data on which ride-along message would drive the highest response from Informed Delivery® subscribers within their mailing file.

The Approach

The Pirates structured their mail campaign as three simultaneous Informed Delivery® campaigns, each testing a different ride-along CTA against the same physical mail piece: a generic "Get tickets today" prompt; a ride-along mirroring the $5-off offer already featured on the physical piece; and a ride-along introducing a separate incentive — a free jersey — not featured on the physical mail at all.

The Results

The findings established a clear hierarchy: specificity outperforms generality, and exclusive digital incentives available only to subscribers who act on the preview produce the strongest response lift.

Ride-Along Variant	Result vs. Generic CTA Baseline
Generic CTA ("Get tickets today")	Baseline
Mirrored $5-off discount	+9% response rate
Exclusive free jersey offer (digital-only incentive)	+39% response rate

> ***"A 39% response rate lift — from a single ride-along image change. The digital-only incentive outperformed mirrored content by more than 4:1."***

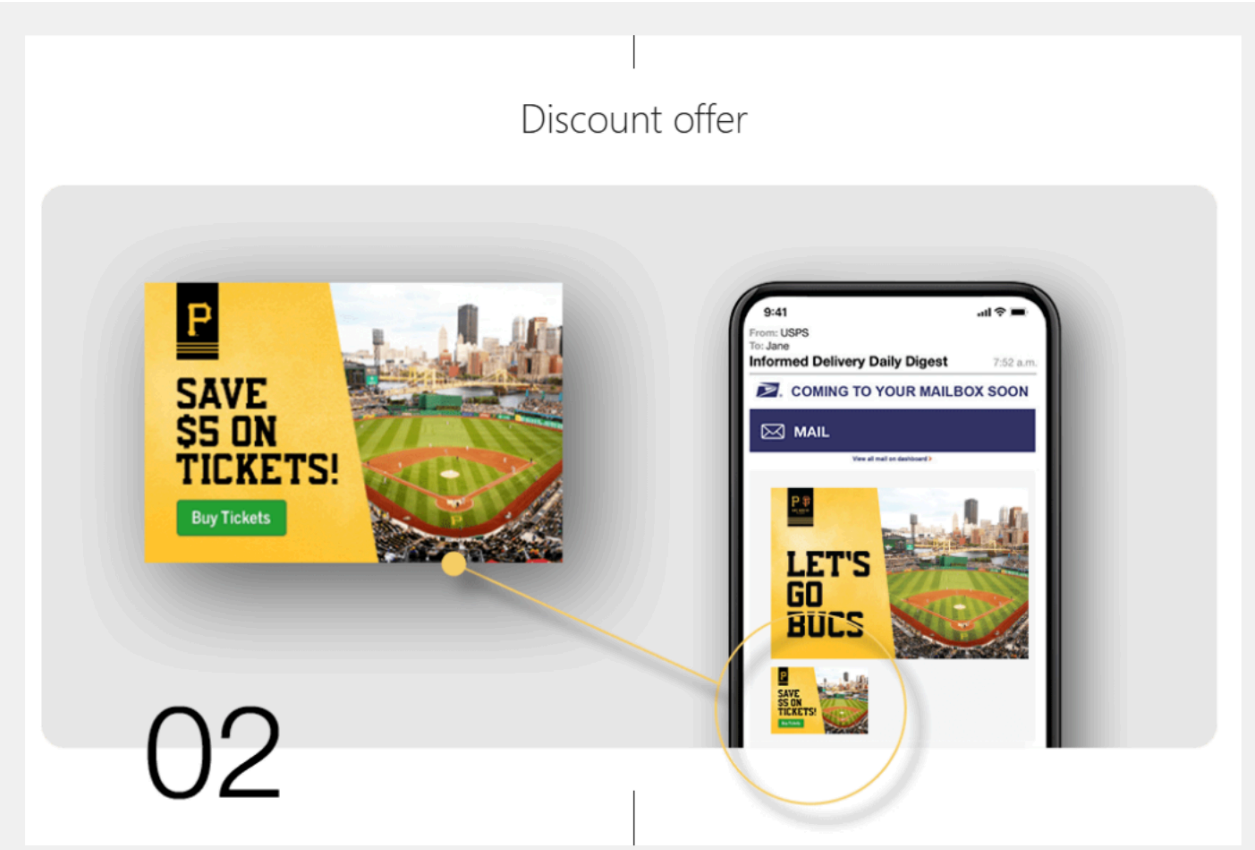


Figure 6: Pittsburgh Pirates ride-along test variants. The digital-only free jersey offer (right) produced a 39% higher response rate than the generic CTA (left). Source: USPS® Delivers.

Case Study 2: Bono's Pit Bar-B-Q — Grayscale vs. Full Color

The Challenge

Bono's Pit Bar-B-Q, a Florida-based restaurant chain, was running a direct mail campaign offering $10 off to customers. The organization wanted to understand whether the default grayscale scan of the actual mailpiece versus a full-color branded graphic had a meaningful impact on subscriber engagement.

The Approach

Bono's ran two simultaneous campaigns against the same mail file. One used the default grayscale scan of the actual mailpiece as captured by USPS® sorting equipment. The other used a full-color representative image of the brand's design

All other variables — ride-along CTA, destination URL, physical mailpiece — remained identical.

The Results

The grayscale mailpiece image produced a 35% higher click-to-open rate than the full-color representative image. This aligns with platform-wide data published by USPS® : across thousands of Informed Delivery® campaigns, grayscale mailpiece images produce click-to-open rates 13% higher on average than full-color alternatives.

The explanation is contextual: the grayscale scan signals an actual incoming mailpiece, creating anticipation and recognition that a polished full-color graphic cannot replicate in the same digest environment.

> ***"Grayscale outperformed full color by 35%. Context drives click more than production value."***

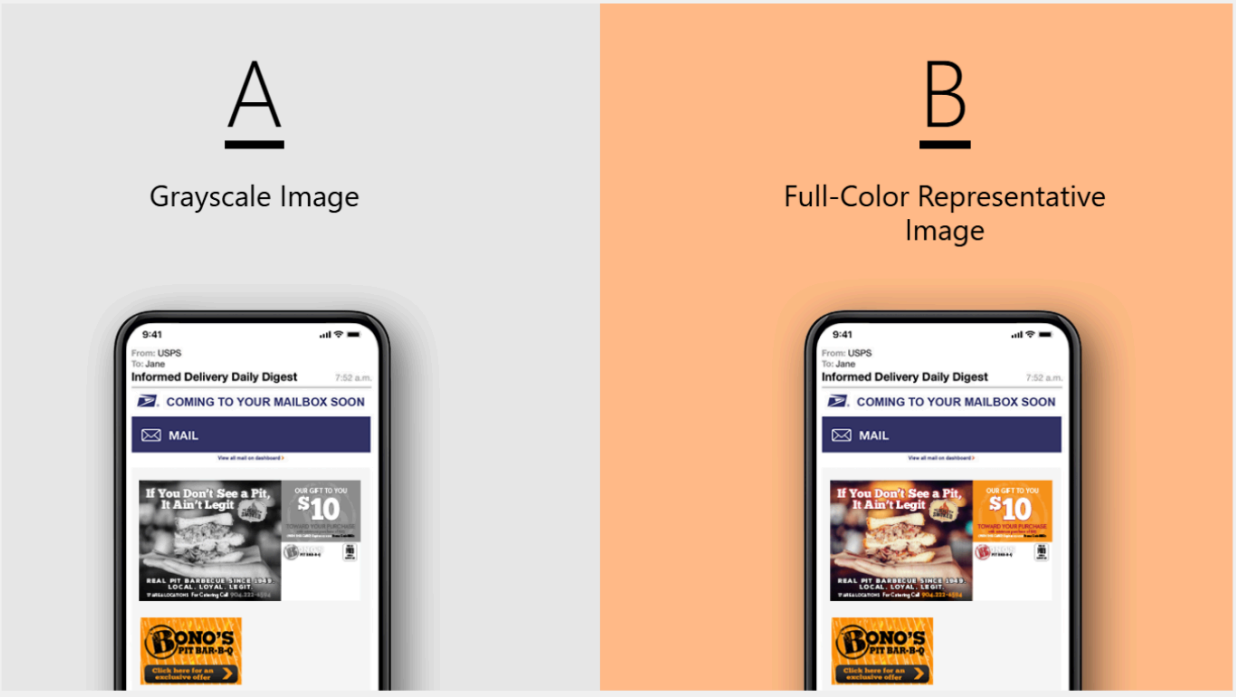


Figure 7: Bono's Pit Bar-B-Q test — grayscale scan (left) vs. full-color image (right). Grayscale outperformed by 35% in click-to-open rate. Source: USPS® Delivers.

Implications for Not-For-Profit Orgs and Small Business Mailers

These two documented cases establish principles with direct application across organization types and campaign objectives.

First, ride-along offer architecture matters more than creative execution. An exclusive digital incentive — something the recipient cannot access from the physical mailpiece alone — produces the strongest response lift. For non-profits running sizable year-end appeals, this suggests testing a ride-along that offers a matching gift window, a named recognition level, or an early-bird acknowledgment available only-to subscribers who click through before the physical letter arrives.

Second, authenticity outperforms production value in the digest environment. Platform-wide data establishes that subscribers respond to the recognition of an actual incoming mailpiece more strongly than to branded advertising. Design briefs for ride-along images should begin with the physical mailpiece — not with brand guidelines developed for other channels.

For non-profits evaluating postage structure and mailing strategy alongside Informed Delivery® implementation, see Cornerstone Services, Inc.'s non-profit mailing resources and direct mail services.

Section 6: Measuring ROI

Informed Delivery® 's value is only measurable if its contribution to campaign performance can be isolated and reported before the campaign launches, not reconstructed afterward.

Available Metrics From the USPS® Portal

• Impressions: Number of Daily Digest opens containing the campaign ride-along

• Unique clicks: Number of subscribers who clicked the ride-along image

• CTR by ZIP Code™: Click-through rate segmented geographically — identifies highestresponse markets

• Engagement by delivery day: Timing patterns that inform future campaign scheduling

Tracking Conversions

USPS® portal metrics document logistics in the pre-delivery window. Connecting such activity to downstream conversions requires additional setup:

• UTM parameters (tags appended to the ride-along URL) distinguish Informed Delivery® traffic from organic web visits in Google Analytics or comparable platforms

• Unique landing pages per campaign eliminate attribution ambiguity entirely

• Non-profit organizations using, for example, Raiser's Edge or Salesforce NPSP software might tag online gifts arriving via Informed Delivery® referral URLs at source — separating digital-preview conversions from reply card responses within the same campaign.

Recommended Measurement Structure: Three-Group Design

• Group A: Informed Delivery® subscribers receiving mail with ride-along activation

• Group B: Informed Delivery® subscribers in the same mail file receiving mail without ridealong activation (grayscale scan only)

• Group C: Non-subscribers receiving physical mail exclusively

This structure isolates two variables simultaneously: the incremental contribution of the ride-along above the grayscale scan alone, and the effect of any Informed Delivery® exposure against a pure mail-only baseline.

Cost Structure by Mail Volume

The following scenarios assume ride-along creative design as the only incremental cost, since USPS® charges no distribution fee. CPM (Cost Per Mille) = cost to generate 1,000 impressions.

Mail Volume	Est. ID® Subscribers (34.7%)	Creative Cost (design only)	Effective Incremental CPM
5,000 pieces	~1,735	$400–$800	$230–$460
10,000 pieces	~3,470	$400–$1,200	$115–$345
25,000 pieces	~8,675	$800–$1,500	$92–$173
50,000 pieces	~17,350	$1,000–$1,500	$58–$87
100,000 pieces	~34,700	$1,000–$1,500	$29–$43

Notes on this model: Creative cost estimates are illustrative ranges based on industry-standard design pricing; actual costs vary by provider and complexity. The 34.7% penetration rate is a national average — actual subscriber rates in a given mail file will vary. CPM figures are calculated against incremental creative cost only; they do not represent the cost of the underlying mailing.

For not-for-profit organizations and small to medium-sized businesses mailing at the 5,000– 10,000 level: these figures are best evaluated not as standalone digital advertising but as incremental impressions against the same audience at the moment of highest receptivity. For campaign-specific projections, the USPS® ROI Calculator provides estimates based on mail volume and file composition.

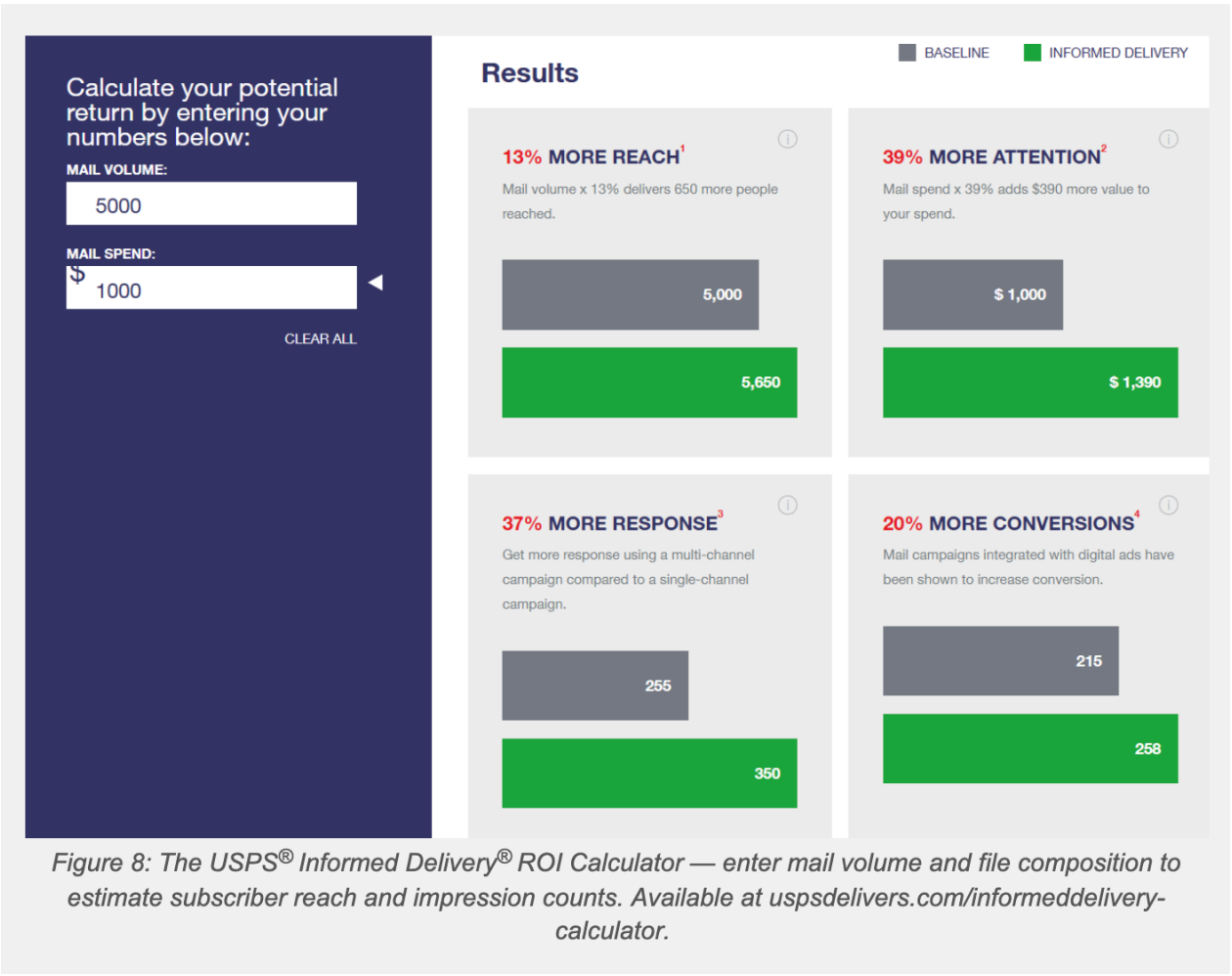


Figure 8: The USPS® Informed Delivery® ROI Calculator — enter mail volume and file composition to estimate subscriber reach and impression counts. Available at uspsdelivers.com/informeddelivery-calculator.

USPS® Postage Promotion Discount: Qualifying Informed Delivery® campaigns can earn a 1% postage discount (plus an additional 0.5% for eDoc submitters) under USPS® annual promotions programs (as available). For high-volume mailers, this discount could assist in offseting a meaningful portion of the creative and setup costs. See PostalPro® at postalpro.usps.com/promotions for current eligibility periods and technical requirements.

Conclusion: Five Structural Advantages — and What They Require

The strategic case for USPS® Informed Delivery® adoption does not rest on projections. It rests on documented platform performance, auditable campaign data, and a cost structure that holds across mail volumes, geographic compositions, and organizational sizes.

As of March 2025, 72.9 million active subscribers receive the Daily Digest email at a 60.1% open rate — more than double the benchmark for standard marketing email. Five structural advantages distinguish Informed Delivery® from alternative digital channels:

Advantage	What It Means in Practice
Universal email accessibility	Reaches 95%+ of U.S. households through basic email — no broadband, app downloads, or social media accounts required. Does not systematically exclude rural populations or older donors.
Geographic parity	34.7% household penetration consistent across urban, suburban, and rural markets. Eliminates the segmentation complexity and parallel campaign management that conventional omnichannel strategies demand.
Unified measurement	Impression counts, click-through rates by ZIP Code™, and conversion path data close the attribution gap traditional mail cannot address.
No rural CPM premium	Zero incremental distribution fee regardless of geographic mail composition — eliminating the 60–80% rural premium that social media platforms systematically charge for geographically dispersed audience files.
Dual response path	Accommodates both digital conversion (recipients who act on the preview) and physical response (recipients who prefer the mailpiece). Both paths are attributable within the same campaign framework.

The implementation complexity that prevents most organizations from accessing these advantages is once again a significant resources consideration for campaign adoption. Business Customer Gateway registration, Mailer ID and CRID configuration, Intelligent Mail® barcode integration, ride-along image specification compliance, campaign timing coordination, UTM parameter setup, and post-campaign analytics extraction represent a technical overhead that development teams and marketing departments running lean operations often cannot readily absorb.

> ***"The platform is free. The expertise to execute it well is not. That distinction is where results are made."***

Why Partner with Professional Mailers

Professional mailing firms such as Cornerstone Services, Inc. (www.crst.net) have the advantage of helping assess cost-reward benefits and ought to be able to provide an accelerated speed of campaign execution. For any mailer with knowledge and experience using Informed Delivery® , one would ideally partner with a provider who could assist with Business Customer Gateway registration- MID and CRID configuration, IMb® integration, campaign timing, ride-along design, and post-campaign analytics on behalf of client organizations.

What Cornerstone Services, Inc. Handles	Value to Your Organization
Business Customer Gateway registration & CRID/MID configuration	No setup errors; campaigns display correctly from day one
IMb® barcode generation and integration	Campaign eligibility confirmed before mail entry
Ride-along image design and USPS® pre-approval	Specification compliance; no delays from rejected creative
Campaign timing coordination with mail production schedule	Correct in-home dates; no missed windows
Post-campaign analytics and reporting	Board-ready data in standard attribution format



Figure 9: Cornerstone Services, Inc. — New Paltz, NY. Direct mail and printing specialists serving the Hudson Valley since 1998.

> ***"One mail drop. Two touchpoints. Zero additional postage. That's USPS® Informed Delivery® — and 72.9 million households are already enrolled."***

Bibliography & Source Citations

All statistical claims in this white paper are sourced from primary or directly authoritative sources. Sources are listed by section. All URLs verified as of March 2026.

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• USPS® Significant Dates in History (Informed Delivery® 2017 nationwide launch): https://about.usps.com/who/profile/history/significant-dates.htm

• FedScoop — USPS® Tech Strategy, Informed Delivery® growth data (2019 figures, Bob Dixon quotes): https://fedscoop.com/usps-tech-strategy-delivers-big-digital-results-formailers-and-customers/

• USPS® Informed Delivery® Business Mailers page: https://www.usps.com/business/informed-delivery.htm

• USPS® Informed Delivery® Year in Review (April 2024–March 2025): https://www.usps.com/business/pdf/informed-delivery-year-review.pdf

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• USPS® Facts — Trademark listing (Informed Delivery® , EDDM® , IMb® , etc.): https://facts.usps.com/informed-delivery-100000-customers/

Section 2 — Consumer Benefits & Competitor Comparison

• Pitney Bowes — USPS® vs. UPS® vs. FedEx® comparison: https://www.pitneybowes.com/us/blog/usps-vs-ups-vs-fedex-best-rates.html

• ShipScience — UPS® My Choice® features and pricing: https://www.shipscience.com/what-is-ups-mychoice-and-how-can-it-benefit-you/

Section 3 — Setup & Campaign Mechanics

• USPS® Business Customer Gateway: https://gateway.usps.com/eAdmin/view/signin

• USPS® PostalPro® — Informed Delivery® resources: https://postalpro.usps.com/id

• USPS® Informed Delivery® FAQs (official PDF — ride-along cost, political mail, CRID): https://www.usps.com/business/pdf/informed-delivery-faqs.pdf

• USPS® Informed Delivery® Campaign Best Practices (official PDF): https://www.usps.com/business/pdf/informed-delivery-campaign-best-practices.pdf

• 2025–2026 USPS® Promotions — Informed Delivery® 1% discount: https://postalpro.usps.com/promotions

Section 5 — Case Studies

• USPS® Delivers — Informed Delivery® Case Studies (Pittsburgh Pirates, Bono's Pit BarB-Q): https://www.uspsdelivers.com/informed-delivery-case-studies/

Section 6 — ROI & Measurement

• USPS® ROI Calculator: https://www.uspsdelivers.com/informeddelivery-calculator/

• ANA Response Rate Report — via Postalytics: https://www.postalytics.com/direct-mailstatistics/

• Modern Postcard — Direct Mail Stats (161% median ROI): https://www.modernpostcard.com/blog/direct-mail-stats

• USPS® Year in Review (20–37% response rate lift): https://www.usps.com/business/pdf/informed-delivery-year-review.pdf

Trademark Notices

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Ready to add Informed Delivery® to your next campaign?

Contact Cornerstone Services, Inc. → | Direct Mail Services → | Non-Profit Mailing → | EDDM® Services →

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